

film reviews Style Magnolias

FASHION

Rating: ★★☆☆☆

Director: Madhur Bhandarkar

Starring: Priyanka Chopra, Kangana Ranaut, Mugdha Godse

Sisterhood movies, a powerful Oscar-making genre in Hollywood, are practically non-existent in testosterone-led Mumbai. Strong women who stand up for themselves, and others, are either cast as vamps or killed at the end. Clearly, it pleases some twisted people out there to have Bollywood women constantly at each other's throats. Not so in *Fashion*, which begins, as all Bhandarkar movies do, as an anthropological exercise. Gay designers who sleep with struggling models, corporate tycoons who like to hang out with beautiful women, vacant



THE CLEAVAGE CLAN: (L TO R) Godse, Chopra and Ranaut

socialite clients, and the drugs-alcohol-sex gross behind the gloss. But for once, Bhandarkar isn't thumping the podium. He gives his lead heroine spunk and sass, and a grateful Chopra, who has lately been very good in some very bad movies, sinks her pretty white teeth into it. Godse is a revelation as the upright B-list model who's not hungry enough though Ranaut's bird-in-freefall act is now somewhat

repetitive. The fringe players have all done their homework, and even though Bhandarkar is a little too in love with staging fashion shows, the movie manages to rescue him from the low life-low budget groove he was stuck in. Fashion is boring? Nah. Try watching the showstopper at the end and it almost convinces you that looking sharp in a smart dress is like rocket science.

Almost. **by Kaveer Banzai**

Manic Mayhem

GOLMAAL RETURNS

Rating: ★★☆☆

Director: Rohit Shetty

Starring: Ajay Devgan, Kareena Kapoor

Bhagwan ke ghar mein sher hai, shamsher nahin. Ha ha. If Lara Dutta married Brian Lara what would that make her? Lara Lara. Ha ha. Not really. *Golmaal Returns* is full of such ridiculous lines, aimed with precision at the five-year-olds in mind and body. It's better written than the noxious original whose success took everyone, including the filmmakers, by surprise. The crotch-a-minute jokes are



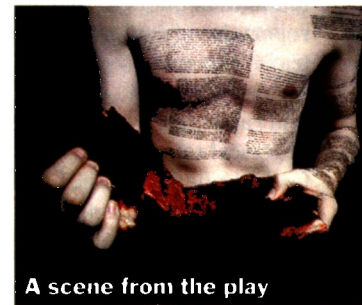
POINT OF NO RETURN: A scene from *Golmaal Returns*

still there as are the politically incorrect stereotypes, from south Indians to the speech-impaired. But there is now a knowing smirk as well, which presumes the audience is familiar with the celebrity tittle-tattle. It is. So there are references to Saif Ali Khan's Kareena

tattoo to Tusshar Kapoor's relationship to the queen of soaps, to Sanjay Leela Bhansali films. It is spirited, energetic, and everyone, it has to be said, tries very hard to keep a straight face. It is also superficially, and sporadically, entertaining. **-KB**

theatre Playful Tryst

MUMBAI Howard Barker has come to be acknowledged as one of the major playwrights in Europe although he remains relatively unknown in his own country, Britain. It is said that over 30 of his works have been staged in seven languages in countries ranging from Canada and New Zealand to Slovenia in the last three years. The credit for introducing Barker's work to an uninitiated audience and also for staging some of the best theatre ever



A scene from the play

seen in India goes to Rehaan Engineer who has taken Barker's description of his work—Theatre of Catastrophe—and converted it into a new sensory theatrical experience with his productions. His latest tryst with Barker's work will see the Indian premier of *A House of Correction*. Barker's play is said to be a tale of 'passion against duty amid the brinkmanship of war'. And, if his past explorations of Barker's works are anything to go by, the play will become a much-awaited and must-watch performance for all lovers of theatre. At NCPA Experimental. From November 4 to November 5.

by Nirmala Ravindran